

MANDAR DEODHAR

THEIR SEPARATE WAYS
Maharashtra CM Devendra Fadnavis with Deputy CM Eknath Shinde in Mumbai

Sena, apparently worked against the BJP. Result: the NCP (SCP) romped home. In Aurangabad, Shinde Sena leaders like ex-minister Abdul Sattar backed the eventually victorious NCP (SCP). Members of the Mahayuti and Maha Vikas Aghadi clearly don't reserve love for the same side or hate for the other.

THE DIVORCE THREAT

Not just at the hyperlocal level either. Post-results, Shinde Sena leader and ex-MLA Ravindra Dhangekar shot the first arrow, calling for his boss to return as CM. Fuelling the fire, Sattar said it was for the BJP to decide on whether "the Mahayuti should continue or not"—the 2024 assembly poll, he recalled, had been won under Shinde's leadership. BJP megaphones issued angry counters. Insiders say all this open warfare can't have happened without the nod of the bosses. Dhangekar soon bowled another googly. Invoking Sena founder Bal Thackeray, he said Uddhav was his "bloodline descendant" and Shinde his "ideological inheritor"—hence, the two were "like brothers" and could "come together in the future".

Fadnavis, no mean bat himself, read the spin in the air and reached out to smother it. He was soon seen at an event flanked by Uddhav and cousin Raj Thackeray. A BJP senior helpfully offered the commentary: it was a stern message to the two allies that the party had its options open. A medley of voices corroborate that tangentially. Atul Londhe Patil, general secretary of the state Congress, claims the BJP may engineer a split in the Sena to cut Shinde down to size. UBT Rajya Sabha MP Sanjay Raut predicts a political upheaval in Delhi in April-May 2027, with tremors locally.

The acrimony is such that a senior BJP MLA jokes the real opposition is within the ruling alliance. The two lose no effort to spite each other. After the murder of a UBT functionary in Thane, the BJP was rumoured to have amplified the family's protests against an ex-mayor, a Shinde loyalist, and her husband, who were questioned multiple times by the police. When Fadnavis backed a 3,000 MW pumped storage scheme in Karjat, which requires some 32,000 trees to be felled in the verdant uplands of coastal Raigad, Uddhav's ecologically-minded son Aaditya opposed it. Shinde Sena and Ajit NCP leaders also joined in, isolating the BJP.



Takeaways

- **Shinde Sena strikes while iron is hot, calling for his return as CM, even threatening a Sena reunion idea**
- **Internal dissent said to be part of reason for Nagpur loss, Mahayuti allies openly hurt BJP elsewhere**
- **Jarange-Patil's Bribegate fans fire, rivalling Shinde for Maratha hero status**

The allies call out its "big brother" vibe, but a BJP man projects blame outward, saying Shinde is an "ambitious politician" who wants to be seen as an undisputed Maratha leader after former deputy CM Ajit Pawar's death in an air crash. This is the space now roiled by the tapes—ostensibly a bid by Jarange-Patil, once seen as close to Shinde, to reinforce his own standing among Marathas. "Of Marathwada's 46 MLAs, the Mahayuti has 41...26 are Marathas," says an analyst. "The BJP, without an overarching Maratha face, is particularly vulnerable." An odd gap for a party ruling Maharashtra, one accentuated by a Brahmin CM. ■